

REMAX® Homebuyer's Guide

A turn-by-turn look at buying
your home with confidence.





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The Road Home

Home means something different to everyone. A first place to call your own. A fresh start. A space to grow. A long-held goal within reach.

Buying a home is a meaningful step. One that deserves clear guidance and reliable information.

Inside the REMAX Homebuyer's Guide, you'll find the essentials of the homebuying process, key terms to know, helpful checklists and considerations to help you make informed decisions.

The road home is personal. A REMAX agent can help you navigate it.

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REMAX Gets You Home

For more than 50 years, REMAX has connected buyers and sellers around the world through a network of experienced real estate professionals.

Nobody in the world sells more real estate than REMAX.¹

Why Choose REMAX

When you work with a REMAX agent, you're working with someone who understands your local market and has the strength of a global network behind them. Someone in your community. And, in your corner.

REMAX agents have been voted the #1 most trusted real estate agents in the U.S. and Canada, year after year.²

1. As measured by residential transaction sides. 2. Voted most trusted Real Estate Agency brand by American and Canadian shoppers based on the BrandSpark® American Trust Study (2022–2025, 2019) and Canadian Trust Study (2021–2026, 2019, 2017).



10 Steps to Buying a Home

1. Choose a real estate agent.
2. Understand your budget.
3. Explore mortgage options and get preapproved.
4. Create a remax.com/remax.ca account and browse homes.
5. Identify homes that interest you and schedule tours.
6. Make an offer.
7. Schedule a home inspection.
8. Close on your home.
9. Set up utilities and transfer services.
10. Move into your new home.

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Confidence at Every Turn

Every home search has its twists and turns. The right agent makes the road ahead clear.

A REMAX agent brings local insight, real-time market knowledge and steady direction at every step, from showings to negotiations to paperwork. You focus on finding the right home. Your agent handles the details.

When you're ready, connect with a local REMAX agent at remax.com (U.S.) or remax.ca (Canada).

Signs of the Right Agent

Deep local insight and lifestyle knowledge

Look at recent sales. Ask around. Read reviews.

A good listener

You should feel heard, understood and comfortable asking questions.

Experience that adapts

Markets shift. A seasoned professional knows how to respond and when to negotiate.

Clear communication

Timely updates. No guessing where things stand.

Ask the Right Questions

- How will you help me compete in today's market?
- How do you evaluate whether a home is priced correctly?
- What should I know about the areas I'm considering?
- How will you keep me informed as we move through the process?
- What strategies do you use when negotiating offers?
- What potential risks or issues should I watch for when buying a home?
- What happens between an accepted offer and closing?



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Turn by Turn

Preapproval

Before you start touring homes, getting preapproved can give you an advantage. When the right home appears, you'll be ready to act. Preapproval begins with a mortgage application and a review of your finances.

Lenders typically look at a few key areas:

Credit

Your credit score and history help determine loan eligibility.

Employment and income

Lenders review your work history and income to confirm your ability to make mortgage payments.

Assets and debts

You may be asked for tax records, bank statements and current debt details to understand your overall financial picture.

Loan options

Mortgage programs vary. Your REMAX agent can help guide you through the process and connect you with the right resources.



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Turn by Turn

Home Search

This is where it gets exciting. From single-family homes to condos, new builds to established communities, today's market offers more choice than ever. The key isn't seeing everything. It's knowing what fits you.

Start by getting clear on your priorities:

- Set a budget — and respect it.
- Choose the location that supports your lifestyle.
- Decide how much space you truly need.
- Separate must-haves from nice-to-haves.
- Consider outdoor living — yard, balcony or none at all.

Once you know what matters most, the search becomes more focused.

Browse listings on [remax.com](https://www.remax.com) (U.S.) or [remax.ca](https://www.remax.ca) (Canada). When something stands out, your REMAX agent can arrange showings, provide community details and help guide your next steps.

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Turn by Turn

Online Search

Photos tell part of the story. Your REMAX agent can help fill in the rest.

Analyze the photos

Study each image. Notice window placement and natural light. Consider how the layout might work for your lifestyle. If the home is staged, look beyond the décor and imagine the space as your own.

Note potential updates

Identify what works, and what may need attention. Some changes are simple, like paint or fixtures. Others may require more planning.

Evaluate outdoor space

Don't overlook what's outside. Balcony, patio or yard, consider how you'll use the space and the upkeep it may require.

Explore virtual tours

3D and virtual walk-throughs can reveal layout and flow, helping you understand how rooms connect before you visit in person.

Interactive visualization

On remax.com, buyers can use the AI Visualizer to explore and personalize a space directly from the listing page, experimenting with different styles in real time.





Find Your Lane

Use this checklist to identify what matters most. Fill it out and review it with your REMAX agent to help refine your home search.

Bedrooms: ☐ 2+ ☐ 3+ ☐ 4+
Bathrooms: ☐ 1+ ☐ 2+ ☐ 3+ ☐ 4+
Dedicated Office Space: ☐ Yes ☐ No
Central Air Conditioning: ☐ Yes ☐ No
☐
☐

Garage: ☐ 1-car ☐ 2-car ☐ 3+ car
☐ Attached ☐ Detached ☐ None
☐

Kitchen Features:
☐ Gas Stove/Cooktop ☐ Gas Oven
☐ Center Island ☐ Dishwasher
☐ Walk-in Pantry ☐ Eat-In Kitchen
☐ Updated Countertops
☐ Fully Renovated
☐

Primary Bedroom Features:
☐ Walk-in Closet ☐ Primary Bathroom
☐

Bathroom Features:
☐ Double Vanity and Sinks
☐ Bathtub ☐ Double Shower
☐

Additional Indoor Features:
☐ Gas Fireplace ☐ Wood Fireplace
☐ Mudroom ☐ Main Level Laundry
☐ Alarm System ☐ Smart-Home Tech
☐ Basement ☐ First-Floor Primary
☐ Energy Efficient ☐ Open Concept
☐ Separated Living Spaces
☐ Mounted TV or Sound System Wiring
☐ Dedicated Dining Room
☐ Bonus Room/Loft Area
☐

Outdoor Features:
☐ Yard Space ☐ Wooded Lot ☐ Balcony
☐ Pool ☐ Fence ☐ Shed
☐ Balcony or Deck
☐ Outdoor Entertaining Area
☐



Home Styles

From classic to contemporary, homes come in many forms. Understanding the differences can help you recognize what fits your lifestyle.

Detached Homes

Two-Story

Two full levels of living space, often with living areas on the main floor and bedrooms above. Some also include a basement for extra space.

Story-and-a-Half (Cape Cod)

A classic design with a steep roofline and simple, symmetrical charm. Dormer windows often add light and usable space to the upper level.

Split-Level

Built around staggered floors connected by short staircases. Living areas, bedrooms and lower levels are separated across distinct levels of the home.

Single-Level (Bungalow)

All living space sits on one floor, creating an easy, accessible layout. Some include a basement or walk-out lower level for additional living space.

Attached Homes

Townhouse

An individually owned home connected to neighboring units in a row. Owners usually share exterior maintenance and community amenities through an association.

Condominium

A privately owned residence within a larger building or community. Monthly fees typically cover shared spaces, maintenance and amenities.

Twin/Semi-Detached Home

Two homes joined by a shared wall, each with its own entrance and address. Ownership is separate, though some exterior maintenance or shared spaces may be managed jointly.

Duplex

A single property designed as two separate living spaces, either side by side or stacked. Duplexes typically share one address with separate units and are often owned by one property owner.

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Your Move

You've found the one. Now it's time to take these steps.

Purchase insurance

If you're financing the home, homeowners' insurance is required. Make sure your coverage protects both the property and your belongings.

Schedule a home inspection

An inspection helps identify potential issues before closing. If significant concerns arise, the purchase agreement may allow you to renegotiate, or walk away.

Confirm utility status

Check that all utilities are current and arrange for service to transfer to your name at closing. For vacant homes, confirm services are active and systems are functioning properly.

Need a Referral?

Your REMAX agent can help connect you with experienced professionals, including:

- Mortgage lender
- Inspector or appraiser
- Moving company
- Insurance provider
- Contractor
- Landscaper



Tax Considerations

Buying a home can change your tax picture. Mortgage interest, property taxes and other expenses may be deductible.

For guidance on what may apply to you, consult a tax professional or visit your local tax authority's website.

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Along the Way

As you move through your homebuying journey, you'll hear terms that shape each step. Knowing what they mean helps you navigate the road ahead.

Amortization

The timeline for paying off a mortgage through scheduled payments. The amortization period determines how long it will take to fully repay the loan.

Balanced Market

A market where the number of buyers and homes for sale are relatively equal. Prices tend to remain stable and homes often sell within a typical timeframe.

Bridge Financing

A short-term loan that helps cover the gap between buying a new home and selling your current one.

Buyer's Market

When more homes are available than there are buyers. Buyers often have more choices and stronger negotiating power.

Closing

The final step of the transaction, when all conditions have been met and ownership officially transfers to the buyer.

Closing Costs

Expenses paid at closing that are separate from the purchase price. These may include legal fees, administrative costs and other transaction-related charges.



Comparative Market Analysis (CMA)

A report that compares similar homes recently sold in the area to help estimate a property's market value.

Condominium Ownership

Ownership of an individual unit within a shared building or community. Owners also share responsibility for common spaces through monthly condo fees.

Contingencies

Conditions written into an offer that must be met before the sale can proceed, such as financing approval or a satisfactory inspection.

Deposit

An upfront payment made when an offer is accepted. It demonstrates the buyer's commitment and is applied to the purchase price at closing.

Down Payment

The upfront portion of the purchase price you pay when buying a home. Smaller down payments may require mortgage insurance.

Due Diligence

Your window to review everything about the home. This is the time to inspect the property, review disclosures and make sure the purchase still feels right.

Earnest Money

A deposit submitted with an offer to show you're serious about buying the home. It's typically applied to closing costs or the purchase price.

Equity

The difference between what your home is worth and what you still owe on the mortgage. As you pay down the loan—or the home's value rises—your equity grows.

First-Time Homebuyer Assistance

Programs that may help first-time buyers with down payments, closing costs or financing. Your lender can help identify options you may qualify for.

Fixed-Rate Mortgage

A mortgage with an interest rate that stays the same for the life of the loan.

Home Appraisal

A professional estimate of a home's market value, typically required by lenders before approving a mortgage.

Home Inspection

A detailed evaluation of a home's condition. It can reveal potential issues and give buyers the opportunity to renegotiate or reconsider the purchase.

Land Survey

A document that identifies property boundaries. It confirms what land is included with the home.

Mortgage Insurance

Insurance required when a down payment is less than 20%. It protects the lender if the borrower defaults on the loan.

Mortgage Preapproval

A lender's estimate of how much you may be able to borrow. It helps you shop with confidence and move quickly when you find the right home.

Offer

A legal proposal to purchase a home. Offers often include conditions — such as financing or a home inspection — that must be satisfied before the sale can proceed.

Seller's Market

A market where there are more buyers than homes available. Homes tend to sell quickly, prices may rise and multiple offers are common.

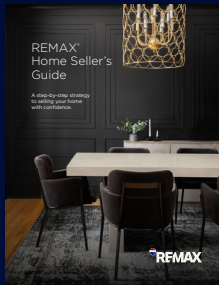
Title Insurance

A policy that protects buyers and lenders from financial loss related to ownership issues, such as title defects or legal claims against the property.

Explore the complete
set of REMAX guides.



REMAX Home Staging Guide



REMAX Home Seller's Guide



remax.com
remax.ca

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1. Voted most trusted Real Estate Agency brand by American and Canadian shoppers based on the BrandSpark® American Trust Study (2022-2025, 2019) and Canadian Trust Study (2021-2026, 2019 and 2017). ©2026 RE/MAX, LLC. Each Office Independently Owned and Operated. 26_162